died unexpectedly, at an awkward moment of vulnerability for the empire, his body was initially hastily buried within the Deenpanah Fort. Then, as Hemu threatened to march upon Delhi, Humayun's body was removed, in even greater haste, to Sirhind. Finally, once the convulsions of empire formation had subsided, sometime in the 1560s, construction was begun for a final resting place for Padshah Humayun. An enormous area, thrumming with political and religious significance, was chosen next to the Yamuna for what would become the first major mausoleum of the Mughals. For this was planned not just as a grave for Humayun but as a family cenotaph for the Mughals and would come to contain some 150 Mughal graves. The site was close to the old Deenpanah Fort but also to the holy burial ground and khanqah* of the towering thirteenth-century Sufi saint Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya because it was considered a great blessing to be buried next to a Sufi saint. The Lodis, old enemies of Babur, were also buried in companionable proximity in what is now known as the Lodi Gardens. The architect for Humayun's tomb was a Persian, Mirak Mirza Ghiyas, who had returned to Hindustan in Humayun's train after his exile. Mirak Mirza Ghiyas had worked extensively not only in Herat and Bukhara but also in India before beginning work on Humayun's tomb.

A huge char-bagh, a paradisiacal garden tomb, with the mausoleum at its centre was designed on a monumental scale in red sandstone and white marble, unprecedented till then. According to tradition and oral records, the primary patron was Humayun's widow, Bega Begum. Bega Begum was the most senior of Humayun's wives, a Timurid cousin of Humayun's and, by Gulbadan's account, a fiercely independent woman who did not hesitate to speak her mind, even to her husband, the Padshah. Now that the turbulence of Akbar's early days were over, Bega Begum devoted herself to her pious duties and became the guardian of her husband's legacy. She left to perform the hajj soon after the construction of the tomb had begun. It is possible, therefore, that Bega Begum oversaw the beginning of the tomb, then left for the hajj and when she returned, she brought back 300 Arab masons and scholars and a new title for herself—Haji Begum.

When she returned to Hindustan, Haji Begum did not settle in Agra at Akbar's court. Unlike Hamida Banu, whose raison d'etre, as seen even in her support of Maham Anaga against Bairam Khan, would be to guard over Akbar's tenacious grip on the empire, Haji Begum relinquished all claims to imperial grandeur and politics upon the death of Humayun. Instead, with